

Shailkumari, Phoolmati, Bhagwani and Paanmati, women who unabashedly claim to be widows wear sindoor, mangalsutra and bangles in sheer mockery of the administration. Then there are cases of both spouses having died but the widow pensions are still being drawn by people who are very much alive. In Azamgarh's Mahula village, 104 out of 187 widow pensioners were found to be fake after the village pradhan and district president of the Uttar Pradesh Pradhan Sangh, Ram Samujh Yadav, wrote to the President and the CBI seeking a probe. A criminal case was then registered against the beneficiaries after an inquiry ordered by District Magistrate Gaurishankar Priyadarshi. The district magistrate of Balia, Senthin Pandiyansi, also ordered a similar investigation which threw up many such cases of fake widow pensioners.



A WIDOW PENSION SCHEME CAMP TO VERIFY RIGHTFUL RECIPIENTS OF THE PENSION IN AZAMGARH

The Widow Pension Scheme fraud is similar to the land scam exposed by INDIA TODAY a decade ago (*Living Dead*, March 22, 1999). Unscrupulous elements in connivance with land revenue officials had declared thousands of land-owners dead in government records and usurped their lands. A decade later, the "dead" are still doing the rounds of courts and government

offices to prove that they are indeed alive and that their lands have been grabbed by others. Disillusioned with the government's apathy, they have formed the Uttar Pradesh Mritik Sangh to contest their cases in court. After INDIA TODAY broke the news, the Lucknow Bench of the Allahabad High Court ordered an inquiry into the fraud. A few officials were suspended but the victims are still doing the rounds of courts for justice.

The annual outgo for 15 lakh widows and 42 lakh other state Government pensioners is a staggering Rs 2,200 crore. For the widows alone, the Uttar Pradesh Government shells out Rs 540 crore annually as pension. Till two years ago, the old and the widowed got Rs 150 per month, which was raised to Rs 300. For those living in abject penury, this is enough to get them through a month of food and basic necessities. Following the exposure of the racket, Samajwadi Party's Lucknow City General Secretary Rajbir Singh Chauhan has demanded a high-level inquiry into the Widow Pension Scheme, claiming that the district administration is deliberately protecting guilty officials.

In Uttar Pradesh, it is not just the Widow Pension Scheme that is being misused to fleece the state Government. A similar embezzlement scam is being reported in the Below Poverty Line benefits and in the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme. For the rightful recipients of pensions, their claims may just remain fleeting ghosts in the darkness of middlemen and government officials.



Ganga Devi and Bihari Lal

Another couple who avail of the pension after Ganga Devi logged her husband as dead in government records